Lesson 30: Editing for Grammar and Mechanics; Keeping an Error Log

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 5.3 Editing Your Draft for Standard Grammar and Mechanics; 5.4 Keeping Track of Your Sentence-Level Grammar Errors.

In this lesson

You edit your revised essay with the book's checklist for grammar, sentence structure, punctuation and mechanics, proofread it, and format the final draft. You also start an error log that works together with the Mistakes page of your tutor app, so that you learn from the errors you make most often. Careful editing shows your reader the attention you gave to your work, and an error log makes each new paper more accurate.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what editing and proofreading involve and why readers notice errors.
- Use the editing checklist to find and correct errors in four areas.
- Proofread with the book's techniques, and use spelling and grammar checkers with care.
- Format a final draft for an academic course.
- Keep an error log linked to the Mistakes page, and edit for your own most frequent errors.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
edit	examine the surface features of a text: spelling, grammar, usage, punctuation and format	Editing comes after revising.
proofread	read a finished draft slowly to find the last mistakes	Read it aloud, or backward.
mechanics	spelling, capital letters, abbreviations and format	"Mechanics and Usage"
usage	the accepted way of using a word	to / too / two
run-on sentence	two independent clauses joined without correct punctuation or a conjunction	Lesson 4
antecedent	the noun that a pronoun refers to	"Is the antecedent of every pronoun clear?"
dangling modifier	a phrase that does not clearly describe any word in the sentence	Lesson 9

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
parallel structure	the same grammatical form for items in a list or pair	Lesson 5
commonly confused words	words that sound or look alike	principle / principal; there / their / they're
spelling checker	software that checks words, not meaning	It cannot see *principal* for *principle*.
format	the layout of a paper: margins, font, spacing, title, page numbers	1-inch margins, double-spaced
error log	your own record of your errors, their rules and their corrections	the Error Analysis Checklist
pattern	an error you make again and again	"seen 5 times" on the Mistakes page

Rules and explanations

Editing comes after revising

Revising improves the **content**: support, unity, coherence and word choice (Lesson 29). Editing examines the **surface**: spelling, grammar, usage and punctuation, and the format of the finished paper. Budget time for it. Readers do not notice correct spelling, but they do notice misspellings; they look past your sentences to your ideas unless the sentences are awkward; they notice when every sentence has the same rhythm; and they notice the care you took with an error-free document.

The editing checklist

Area	Check for	Review
Grammar	sentence fragments; run-on sentences; conjunctions between independent clauses; subject-verb agreement; verb tense and irregular verb forms; subject, object and possessive pronouns; *who/whom*; clear antecedents; pronoun agreement; comparative and superlative forms; dangling modifiers; nouns: number, agreement and articles	Lessons 1, 4, 9, 10
Sentence structure	variety (not only simple sentences); the best coordinating and subordinating conjunctions; long sentences with too much information; parallel structure	Lessons 2, 3, 5
Punctuation	correct end punctuation; a reason for every exclamation point; apostrophes in singular and plural possessives; quotation marks	Lessons 6, 7, 8
Mechanics and usage	spelling; capital letters; abbreviations; commonly confused words (to/too/two); the format your lecturer requires	Lessons 8, 50

The book's checklist has no question about commas, semicolons or colons: add them from Lessons 6 and 7.

Proofreading, and using checkers with care

- A spelling checker cannot recognize that you meant *principle* but wrote *principal*. A grammar checker often questions correct sentences, because it does not understand your meaning. Accept the suggestions that make sense, but consider why each one came up. Do the same with suggestions from an AI tool, including your tutor: ask for the rule.
- Proofreading needs patience: it is easy to read past a mistake. Set the paper aside for a few hours or a day. Some professional proofreaders read a text **backward** to concentrate on spelling and punctuation. Or read the paper **aloud slowly**, paying attention to every word, letter and punctuation mark.
- Ask a reliable reader (your tutor) for a final pass.

Format

For most academic papers: 1-inch margins, Times New Roman 12 point, double-spaced. Follow any specific instructions on titles, margins, page numbers and the place of your name; research papers often follow the APA or MLA style guide. Check the format before you submit.

Psychology note: psychology uses APA style. An APA student paper has a title page, a page number in the top right corner of every page, double spacing, 1-inch margins, a 0.5-inch indent at the start of each paragraph, and a readable font such as 12-point Times New Roman or 11-point Calibri.

Keeping an error log

The book gives an **Error Analysis Checklist** to fill in when your paper comes back with your instructor's comments. It is a picture and is not in your lesson material, so keep your own error log, together with your tutor app's **Mistakes page**.

The Mistakes page. When you write or speak in chat or Live conversation, the tutor records the mistakes it finds. The page groups them by **rule** and shows the category (grammar, vocabulary, spelling, word order or punctuation), how many times the mistake was seen and when, a short explanation, and your examples (wrong → right). The tutor practises your most frequent patterns with you. Mark a pattern **resolved** when you stop making it; it reopens by itself if it comes back.

Your error log. Keep it in a notebook or a document:

Date	Assignment	My sentence	Correction	Rule	Checklist area

How to use it:

1. After every piece of feedback (your tutor's review of a draft, or a new entry on the Mistakes page), copy each error into the log with its rule.
2. Every week, compare your log with the Mistakes page. Which rules have the highest counts?
3. Your three to five most frequent rules are your **personal editing checklist**. Before you finish any paper, read it once for each of them.
4. When a rule disappears from your new writing, mark it resolved on the Mistakes page.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no capital letters, so check capitals for names, titles, nationalities and the first word of each sentence. - Arabic uses the article "al-" with general and abstract nouns, but English does not: write "Education is important" and "Stress affects memory", not "The education ..." or "The stress ...".

Practice

Exercise 1. Edit the books. Each sentence comes from one of the two books in this unit (published books have errors too). Find the error, name the checklist area and question that would catch it, and correct it. Item 1 has two errors.

1. ... background information (the "back story" that give explanation of why you are writing on this topic) ...
2. Learning objectives: "1. Select primary support related to your thesis. 2. Support your topic sentences. 3. Providing connections between thesis and body paragraphs."
3. After evaluating the feedback and assessing what is most helpful, the reader's feedback will help you when you revise your draft.
4. Instead, a topic is introduced at the beginning of a passage and the following sentences offers new information about that one main topic.
5. See if you can finish this sentences from an article on stereotype threat ...
6. That framing helps your audience better understand the argument of your writing by preparing reader for the ideas that are to come in the body of your essay.
7. Later she read books written by African writers like Chinua Achebe and Camara Laye, Adichie felt familiar with the places and characters in the stories.
8. I would participate in speech competitions against children in other schools, and I often one.
9. Lastly, teaching students about stereotype thread can help the students to resist it.
10. To some up, we learn stereotypes from the family and from the media.

Exercise 2. Spelling checkers. Why would a spelling checker not find the errors in items 8, 9 and 10?

Exercise 3. True or false?

1. Readers notice correct spelling.
2. A grammar checker understands your meaning.
3. Some proofreaders read a text backward to concentrate on spelling and punctuation.
4. For most academic papers, use 1-inch margins, 12-point Times New Roman and double spacing.
5. You should edit your sentences before you revise the content.
6. You should accept every suggestion from a grammar checker.

Exercise 4. Start your error log. Open the Mistakes page. Copy your three most frequent patterns into an error log, with one example of each, its correction, its rule, and the checklist area that would catch it. (If the page is still empty, use three errors from Exercise 1.)

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my essay: [paste]. Do not rewrite it. Mark each error, name its checklist area (grammar, sentence structure, punctuation, or mechanics and usage), and let me correct it."
- "What are my most frequent mistakes on my Mistakes page? Give me five sentences for each one to correct."
- "Here are my corrections: [paste]. Are they right? Which rule does each one follow?"
- "In Live conversation: I will read my conclusion aloud slowly, one sentence at a time. Stop me when you hear an error."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 1."

Writing task

Edit and proofread the second draft of your essay from Lesson 29, and produce the **final draft** of your Unit 3 essay. (If you started a new topic, edit the latest draft you have.)

1. Set the draft aside for a few hours or a day.
2. **Personal sweep:** read once for each of the three to five rules in your error log.
3. **Checklist sweeps:** read once for each area: grammar, sentence structure, punctuation (add commas, semicolons and colons), and mechanics and usage.
4. Run a spelling checker, but think about every suggestion.
5. **Proofread:** read the essay aloud slowly; then read it backward, sentence by sentence, for spelling and punctuation.
6. **Format** it: title, 1-inch margins, double spacing, page numbers, and APA citations if you used sources.
7. Paste it into the chat and ask your tutor to mark (not correct) the remaining errors. Correct them, and add each one to your error log.

Self-editing checklist:

- I read once for each of my personal top errors.
- Every sentence is complete, with no fragments, run-ons or comma splices.
- Every verb agrees with its subject and is in the correct tense.
- Every pronoun has a clear antecedent, and every noun has the correct number and article.
- Lists and pairs are parallel.
- Apostrophes, quotation marks, commas and capital letters are correct.
- I checked commonly confused words that a spelling checker cannot catch.
- The format follows the required style.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Grammar: "Does every verb agree with its subject?" and "Have I checked all nouns ... for correct article use?" → the "back story" that **gives an** explanation (the subject of *give* is *that* = the back story, singular; *explanation* here needs *an*).
2. Sentence structure: "Do I see any mistakes in parallel structure?" → 3. **Provide** connections between thesis and body paragraphs.
3. Grammar: "Is it clear which word a participial phrase modifies, or is it a dangling modifier?" The feedback does not evaluate itself; the writer does. → After **you evaluate** the feedback and **assess** what is most helpful, the reader's feedback will help you when you revise your draft. (Or: After evaluating the feedback and assessing what is most helpful, **you can use the reader's feedback** when you revise your draft.)
4. Grammar: "Does every verb agree with its subject?" → the following sentences **offer** new information.
5. Grammar: "Have I checked all nouns for number and agreement ...?" → finish **these** sentences (two sentences follow).
6. Grammar: "... correct article use?" → by preparing **the reader** (or: preparing **readers**).
7. Grammar: "Are some sentences run-on sentences?" / "Do some sentences need conjunctions between independent clauses?" Two independent clauses are joined with only a comma. Correct it in one of these ways: **When she later read** books ... Camara Laye, Adichie felt familiar ...; or ... Camara Laye**.** Adichie felt familiar ... (a period or a semicolon); or ... Camara Laye, **and** Adichie felt familiar ...
8. Mechanics and usage: commonly confused words (one/won) → I often **won**.
9. Mechanics and usage: spelling → stereotype **threat**.
10. Mechanics and usage: commonly confused words (some/sum) → To **sum** up.

Exercise 2 "One", "thread" and "some" are real English words, so a spelling checker accepts them. It checks words, not meaning, just as it cannot see *principal* written for *principle*.

Exercise 3

1. False: readers do not notice correct spelling, but they notice misspellings.
2. False.
3. True.
4. True.
5. False: revise the content first, then edit.
6. False: accept the suggestions that make sense, and consider why each came up.

Exercise 4 (example answer, with errors from Exercise 1)

Date	Assignment	My sentence	Correction	Rule	Checklist area
today	Exercise 1	the following sentences offers new information	the following sentences offer new information	subject-verb agreement	Grammar
today	Exercise 1	by preparing reader for the ideas	by preparing the reader for the ideas	article with a singular count noun	Grammar
today	Exercise 1	Later she read books ..., Adichie felt familiar ...	When she later read books ..., Adichie felt familiar ...	run-on sentence (comma splice)	Grammar

My notes